

Fallacies Workshop

Research Methods

BTM710NBB

10 June 2026

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60 Minutes Overtime: Norah O'Donnell's interview with President Donald Trump

The 60 minutes interview with president Donald Trump contained a plethora of logical fallacies of all kinds. There are two particularly relevant instances that I want to point out:

“Because of tariffs, we have the highest stock market we've ever had. Because of tariffs, 401(k)s at the highest level... Because of tariffs, our country is respected again.” (CBS News, 2025)

While it's certainly unfactual now, at the time, the stock market was doing much better than anticipated, that does not mean there is correlation. This is a prime example of **post hoc**, or **false cause**, where you attempt to correlate two events by juxtaposing them despite the lack of causation. The cause for the rise in the stock market could be for any number of entirely unrelated events, from simply the time of year causing an increase in spending habits, to rising industry success; both separate from tariffs.

Another example from this interview occurs when president Trump attempts to justify his use of unlimited tariff power by saying “If I wasn't allowed to use tariffs on them, we would be a third world nation.” (CBS News, 2025). He claims that there are only two distinct outcomes, one where he uses tariffs and one where the United States of America is a third world nation. This is a case of a **False Dilemma (Black Or White)**, completely ignoring the wide range of middle options, such as acquiring congressional approval, into a strict binary, oversimplifying the complex policy question.

Scholarly Article: When gambling is healthy: the restorative potential of casinos

In this article by Mark Rosenbaum and Ipkin Anthony Wong, the pair analyze tourism within the country of Macau, specifically from mainland China, and draw conclusions from both other literature and their own experiments on the positive effects of gambling. This is a particularly dangerous finding, as it goes against much of the more conventional view that gambling is a problem, but even more damning might be the way they unfairly represented gambling. In the article, they state that "individual restoration that occurs in casinos may be integral to China's mental well-being, in the same manner that service organizations, such as bars, senior day centers, diners, gyms and hair salons, help support mental health." (Rosenbaum and Wong, 2015). They equate casinos with gyms, diners, and hair salons within the category of restorative "third places", but fail to disclose many of the differences that casinos have that the former do not, such as financial loss and addiction risk, both of which are baked into the core activity within the casino: gambling. This is a clear case of a **False Analogy**, the comparison could hold true if the differences were irrelevant or negligible, but not only are the differences quite significant, they are also extremely relevant to the concept of "restoration" that they attribute to gyms, diners, and hair salons.

Formal Declaration of 1200 Scientists: "There is NO CLIMATE EMERGENCY"

"The World Climate Declaration, which has been signed by 1,200 climate scientists and related professionals declare that there is 'no climate emergency'. ... They are led by Norwegian physics Nobel Prize laureate Professor Ivar Giaever," (Dowling, 2022). The article relies on the 1200 scientists and professionals that signed a declaration stating that there is no

climate emergency as evidence against climate change. This attempts to appeal to readers by having 1200 scientists and related professionals as an authoritative figure, even mentioning the head being a Norwegian physics Nobel Prize laureate. However, it's important to know, Professor Ivar Giaever, would argue points that “had long been debunked” (Lalli, 2025). Overall, by crediting the declaration of 1200 scientists and professionals as evidence, it attempts to appeal to readers by having a seemingly authoritative figure backing them.

“Democrats are flat earths who don’t believe in science” (Dowling, 2022). This a clear example of the ad hominem fallacy. Rather than address the arguments, the author attempts to undermine the credibility, validity and character of democrats by equating them with a debunked conspiracy theory.

Don’t Fall for “Conservative” Pitch to Legalize Hard Drugs

“Witness San Francisco, Seattle, and Los Angeles, where district attorneys have refused to prosecute drug violations. The outcome? A precipitous decline in quality of life, a steep increase in street squalor — with human feces on the streets in some places—and a spike in property and violent crime. Because the laws are ignored — hence, drug use is quasi-legalized—large swaths of these once world-class cities have become fetid cesspools — even as the cost of living in these cities has sky-rocketed. What a mess” (Smith, 2022).

This article attempts to use San Francisco, Seattle, and Los Angeles as examples of what would occur if drugs become legalized, but this argument is an example of the false cause fallacy. It states that due to attorneys refusing to prosecute drug violations, it has led to a massive decline for the quality of life whilst ignoring any other factors. Furthermore, the second part of his analysis, saying because drug use was ignored criminally, the cities became a mess;

means he is linking the city's messy state directly with drugs not being prosecuted. He is ignoring any other factor such as, increased homelessness, housing shortages, mental health crises', etc.

"[marijuana related hospitalizations increased during the marijuana legalization experiment, as such,] imagine how much worse it would be if we swept away legal penalties for the abuse of harder, more dangerous drugs. The inevitable outcome would be more addiction, increased deaths, and destroyed families" (Smith, 2022). This argument is a clear example of the slippery slope fallacy. The assertion that legalization of drugs will cause an increase in addiction followed by increased deaths and finally destroyed families as an outcome, makes it a slippery slope fallacy as the predicate for each potential outcome is the legalization of drugs. It's not an example of false cause as this is the potential outcome that would occur if the legalization occurred.

Trump tears into Stephen A Smith as feud grows: 'Arrogant fool, a low IQ individual'

"The president said he wasn't sure that Smith had the 'aptitude' or a 'high IQ' to run for office.' & "Stephen A. Smith is an arrogant fool, a low IQ individual,' Trump wrote in a post on Truth Social. 'In other words, he's 'dumb as a rock,' and totally unqualified to ever think of running for high political office, or even low political office, for that matter!"

In these two passages, it's clear to see that the fallacy being used is the ad hominem fallacy. As Trump's argument is based around the character and intelligence of Stephen rather than any qualifications, policies, experiences, etc, it is a clear example of ad hominem.

Dowling, M. (2022, August 20). *Formal Declaration of 1200 Scientists: “There is NO CLIMATE EMERGENCY.”* Independent Sentinel.

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<https://humanize.today/2022/07/dont-fall-for-conservative-pitch-to-legalize-hard-drugs/>

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<https://www.foxnews.com/outkick-sports/trump-tears-stephen-smith-feud-grows-arrogant-fool-low-iq-individual>